

STRIKING PLATES

STEGOSAURUS

With a neck and back lined with a spectacular double row of plates and a tail armed with four dangerous spikes, *Stegosaurus* was the largest of all the stegosaurs—a group of plant-eating dinosaurs with plates on their backs. The plates were bony structures, called osteoderms, which grew directly from the animal's skin. These were probably covered in tough keratin—the same material that forms the beaks of birds—and might have played a role in display. *Stegosaurus* is known from fossils found in what is now North America and Portugal, which suggests that a land bridge could have connected North America and Europe at the time.

Torvosaurus was one of the biggest predators during the Late Jurassic Period.

Stegosaurus would thrash its flexible tail around to ward off predators.

STATS AND FACTS

Stegosaurus had a strong skull and could bite down with a force of about 88 lb (40 kg), which is powerful for a herbivore. This would have allowed it to feed on a wide variety of tough vegetation.

TAIL SPIKES



The spikes on *Stegosaurus*'s tail grew to a length of 3 in (1 m).

WEIGHT



Paleontologists estimate that the heaviest *Stegosaurus* could have weighed 7.7 tons (7 tonnes).